
DJ DANNY WEST · GUIDE

DFW Wedding DJ *Pricing Guide.*

What it actually costs to book a great wedding DJ in
Dallas–Fort Worth — and how to spot a bad one before you sign.

BY DJ DANNY WEST

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djdannywest.com · Bookings by inquiry

BEFORE YOU SHOP DJs

The honest *DFW DJ market.*

If you're planning a wedding in Dallas, Fort Worth, Plano, Frisco, Arlington, Southlake, McKinney, or anywhere in between, you've probably already noticed the DJ price range is wild. Quotes from \$800 to \$8,000 for what looks like the same service. So which one's right? Here's the answer most planners won't give you straight.

I've been DJing professionally for over twenty years. I'm the official DJ for the Dallas Cowboys' Stadium Club, the SiriusXM Latin mix-show coordinator, and I've played weddings from \$4,000 backyard ceremonies to seven-figure estate events at Marquee on Magnolia and the Adolphus. I'm based in Arlington — DFW is home turf.

“Most couples don't overpay for a DJ. They underpay for the wrong one, then pay twice — once for the DJ, once for the rescue.”

This guide is what I tell every couple who calls. No upsells. No fake scarcity. Just the real numbers, the real tradeoffs, and a checklist you can take to any DJ — me or someone else — so you don't get burned.

Inside this guide:

- The four DFW wedding DJ pricing tiers — what you actually get at each
- Seven red flags that mean walk away (even if the price looks great)
- DFW venue cheat sheet — acoustics, power, and what your DJ needs to know
- Your 12-month music planning timeline
- What's worth paying extra for (and what's not)

PRICING — THE FOUR TIERS

What a DFW wedding DJ costs.

These are real DFW market ranges as of 2026, based on direct quotes I see every week from couples who reach out after talking to other DJs. Every range is for a typical 6–8 hour wedding (ceremony + cocktail hour + reception) with ceremony sound included.

Mileage outside the 20-mile DFW radius, late-night extensions, second-room audio (separate ceremony space), and add-ons like uplighting, monogram projection, or photo booths are typically priced separately at every tier.

TIER 1 — BUDGET**\$800 – \$1,500****BEST FOR**

Backyards, small intimate weddings under 75 guests, weeknights, off-peak months (Jan-Feb, Aug).

WHAT'S USUALLY INCLUDED

- One DJ, 4–5 hours
- Basic two-speaker rig
- One wireless mic
- Spotify-style playlist

WATCH FOR

Often a side-hustler — they may not show up, may not have backup gear, and the “contract” is sometimes a Venmo handshake. Always ask for proof of insurance.

TIER 2 — MID-MARKET**\$1,500 – \$3,000****BEST FOR**

Most DFW weddings, 75–175 guests, standard timeline, mainstream venues like country clubs and hotel ballrooms.

WHAT'S USUALLY INCLUDED

- One DJ, 6 hours
- 4-speaker setup + subwoofer
- 2 wireless mics
- Custom playlist consultation
- MC for toasts & intros

WATCH FOR

Quality is wildly inconsistent in this tier. Many of these DJs are still learning. Ask to hear a recent live mix and watch how they MC on video before booking.

PRICING — TIERS 3 & 4

The upper market.

These are the tiers where you're paying for craft, judgment, and reputation — not just gear. The hardware gap between Tier 2 and Tier 3 is small. The human gap is enormous.

TIER 3 — PREMIUM**\$3,000 – \$6,000****BEST FOR**

150+ guest weddings, multicultural ceremonies (Latin, Indian, Persian, Vietnamese), Cowboys-tier downtown venues, anyone who wants a packed floor not a polite one.

WHAT'S USUALLY INCLUDED

- Veteran DJ (10+ years)
- Full pro audio + lighting
- Multiple mic options
- Vibe consult & do-not-play list
- Ceremony sound included
- Backup gear on-site
- Insured & contracted

WATCH FOR

This is where I sit. At \$4,000–\$5,500 for most DFW weddings, you're paying for someone who has played 500+ events and reads the floor before adjusting.

TIER 4 — LUXURY**\$6,000 – \$12,000+****BEST FOR**

Estate weddings, private clubs (Vaquero, Brook Hollow, Dallas Country Club), 300+ guests, full-production celebrity-style events.

WHAT'S USUALLY INCLUDED

- Touring-level DJ
- Concert-grade rig
- Full intelligent lighting
- Multiple DJs / handoffs
- Live percussion / sax options
- Day-of coordinator liaison
- Custom intro production

WATCH FOR

At this tier, hire someone with a touring or major-stage résumé — not just a wedding-DJ résumé. The skill ceiling matters when the room and the guest list do too.

HOW TO SPOT A BAD DJ

Seven red flags.

I get rescue calls from DFW couples almost every Saturday morning. Here's how to make sure you're never the one calling another DJ from the venue parking lot at 5pm because yours didn't show.

01 — They can't show you a live mix from the last 60 days.

Anyone can fake a website. A real DJ has fresh audio. If they can't send you a SoundCloud, Mixcloud, or video clip from a real event in the last two months, they're not currently working.

02 — They don't carry liability insurance.

Almost every premium DFW venue requires DJs to carry \$1M general liability. If they can't email you a COI in 10 minutes, they're not insured.

03 — “Just send me your Spotify playlist.”

A real wedding DJ reads the floor in real time and adjusts. Playlist DJs are fine for \$800 backyard parties. They're not fine for a \$40,000 wedding.

04 — The contract is a paragraph in a text message.

You should get a real contract with cancellation terms, force majeure, overtime rates, deposit structure, and gear breakdown. No contract, no booking.

05 — They won't tell you what gear they're bringing.

A pro DJ can tell you in detail — speaker model, subwoofer model, mic model, DJ controller model. If they can't, they're either hiding a poor rig or they don't actually know.

06 — They “mostly do clubs” or “mostly do schools.”

Wedding DJing is a separate skill. MCing toasts, navigating family politics, running a coordinated timeline with the planner — none of that happens in a club. Make sure they've done weddings recently.

07 — The price is suspiciously low.

If a DFW DJ is quoting \$500 for a 6-hour Saturday wedding, ask why. It's either a hobbyist, a no-show waiting to happen, or someone with zero credibility trying to build a portfolio on your event.

DFW VENUE CHEAT SHEET

Rooms I know.

Every venue is different — ceiling height, power, sound restrictions, where the dance floor sits. A DJ who's played the room before knows the quirks. Here are some of the DFW spots I've played, and what your DJ needs to know about each.

VENUE	ROOM TYPE	WHAT YOUR DJ NEEDS TO KNOW
The Adolphus, Dallas	Historic hotel ballroom	High ceilings, marble walls — sound bounces. Subs need to be controlled or it's mud. Loadin from the alley.
Four Seasons, Las Colinas	Resort ballroom	Power is solid, room is forgiving. Strict noise curfew at 11pm — plan your final-song moment.
Marquee on Magnolia, Southlake	Luxury wedding venue	Beautiful room but bring your own line array for outdoor ceremony. Indoor reception sound is generous.
The Filter Building, Dallas	Industrial / loft	Concrete + steel = serious reverb. Use directional speakers, not omnidirectional. Floor needs uplighting.
Hickory Street Annex, Dallas	Open warehouse	Massive space, dual zones common. Plan ceremony + reception audio separately.
The Brik, Fort Worth	Industrial wedding venue	High ceilings, exposed brick. Watch monitor placement — feedback is easy here.
Stoney Ridge Villa, Azle	Outdoor estate	Power is limited — confirm generator needs early. No noise ordinance, but neighbors will call by 11.
Hotel Crescent Court, Dallas	Hotel ballroom	Compact dance floor — load-out has to be quick to clear the room for breakfast.
Stonebriar Country Club, Frisco	Country club	Standard ballroom setup. Strict end times — 11pm hard stop is real.
Texas Live!, Arlington	Entertainment district event space	Already wired for events — your DJ can plug into house. Confirm what's included.

MUSIC PLANNING TIMELINE

From 12 months out *to last call.*

12+ MONTHS OUT

Book your DJ. Premium DFW DJs are booked 12–18 months out for peak season (March–May, September–November). If your date is in those windows, you should already be calling.

9 MONTHS OUT

First music conversation. Vibe, energy level, what you do not want. This is the lane-setting call — not a song-by-song planning session.

6 MONTHS OUT

Lock the special-moment songs: processional, recessional, first dance, parent dances, cake cut. If you're doing surprise dances or a band-DJ hybrid, plan choreography now.

3 MONTHS OUT

Build the do-not-play list. Be specific — “no slow Taylor Swift” is more useful than “no boring music.” Add the must-plays your family will text you about later.

1 MONTH OUT

Final timeline meeting with your DJ and planner. Sync on toast order, introductions (parents, wedding party), and the exact moment lights go up.

WEEK OF

Day-of contact info exchange. Your DJ should be in the planner's group chat. Confirm load-in time, dress code, and dinner-break logistics.

DAY OF

Your DJ is there 90 minutes before guests arrive. Soundcheck, mic check, ceremony rehearsal music. If your DJ “just shows up an hour before” — that's a Tier 1 DJ, regardless of what you paid.

ADD-ONS — WHAT'S WORTH IT

Worth it.

Skip it.

WORTH IT

- **Uplighting (\$400–\$800).** Changes a venue more than any other line item. If your venue is plain (a country club ballroom, a hotel banquet room), this is the single highest-ROI add-on you can buy.
- **Ceremony sound (\$200–\$500).** If your ceremony is in a separate room or outdoors, you need a second audio rig. Couples skipping this is the #1 cause of guests yelling “louder!” during vows.
- **Backup DJ on call (\$150–\$300).** Some premium DJs include this. A real wedding-day insurance policy if your DJ gets sick or stuck in traffic.
- **Extra hour buffer (\$200–\$400/hr).** Weddings always run long. Book the extra hour up front — it's half the price of the “day-of overtime” rate most DJs charge.

SKIP IT (usually)

- **Photo booth (\$800–\$1,200) when bundled with a DJ.** The DJ-bundled photo booth is usually a basic one without an attendant. Hire a dedicated photo booth company instead, or skip — guests don't talk about it the next day.
- **Monogram projection (\$300–\$500).** Trendy in 2018, slightly dated now. If you love yours, do it. If you're on the fence, that money is better spent on uplighting.
- **Dance floor “wow lighting” (\$1,500+ for big rigs).** Unless your venue is huge and dark, a competent DJ's standard lighting package is enough. Save the cash.
- **Smoke / fog effects (often \$300+).** Fire codes vary venue to venue, and most DFW venues quietly hate this. Confirm with your planner before paying.

THE 60-SECOND DJ INTERVIEW

Ten questions *that filter fast.*

Read these aloud on any DJ call. If they hesitate or dodge on more than two, move on.

01. Can you send me a live mix from the last 60 days?
02. Are you the DJ I'll be working with on the day, or a different DJ from your roster?
03. Have you played [my venue] before? What's the gear setup that works there?
04. Can you email me your COI (certificate of insurance)?
05. What happens if you can't make my date — what's your backup?
06. How do you handle do-not-play and must-play lists?
07. How does the timeline review work with my planner?
08. What's your overtime rate after [end time]?
09. What's your deposit structure and cancellation policy?
10. What's the gear you'll bring — exact speaker, sub, and mic models?

“The right DJ makes your wedding feel like the best night of the year. The wrong one makes it feel like a corporate retreat. Take the interview seriously.”

LET'S TALK

If we're a fit, *send me your date.*

I take a limited number of DFW weddings each year so I can show up at the level above the average. Most of my bookings come from planner referrals, past clients, and couples who found me the way you just did.

Here's what happens when you send an inquiry from djdannywest.com/book:

- I personally read every inquiry — no agency, no answering service.
- I respond within 24 hours with availability and an honest read on fit.
- If we move forward, we do a 30-minute call to lock the vibe.
- Then a real contract, a real deposit, and a real DJ on your date.

READY TO TALK?

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